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Army Commander
The Penultimate Rung

En route to Shimla, I called on the army chief, General N.C. Vij. He congratulated me on my new assignment, and during our interaction, he asked me to write the doctrine for the army as the GOC-in-C of ARTRAC. There had to be two parts to it – one for the public domain, and the other classified, covering operational aspects. I started working on this from day one. The salubrious climate of Shimla was extremely conducive for creativity and conceptual work. My office was in a historical building, constructed in the nineteenth century to house the General HQ of the British Imperial Army. Though the top two floors of the seven- or eight-storeyed building had got burnt down, it was still a very imposing building. The fact that the office had been occupied by the likes of General Lord Roberts of Kandhar (1885–93), General Viscount Kitchener of Khartoum (1902–09), General Sir Philip W. Chetwode (1930–35), whose words are enshrined in the Chetwode Hall of the Indian Military Academy, General Sir Claude J.E. Auchinleck and General Sir Archibald P. Wavell (the second last governor general of India), to name a few, who were all commanders-in-chief of the Indian Army, was an unbelievable high. What must have happened in the exalted wood-panelled and teak-floored chambers and corridors of this famous building is impossible to imagine or describe. The Command House, where we lived for a year, was named the Retreat. It was one of the best houses that I have ever stayed in, and was constructed in 1904 during the glorious period of the Raj.